NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠10

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦Q

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥6

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♦Q

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥Q

Board 1
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 8 5 2 ♥ Q 9 8 6 2 ♦ K Q 6 ♣ A 8	
♠ A K J 9 6 4 ♥ J ♦ 10 5 3 ♣ J 7 4	N W E S	♠ 10 ♥ K 7 4 ♦ 9 8 4 2 ♣ 10 6 5 3 2
	♠ Q 7 3 ♥ A 10 5 3 ♦ A J 7 ♣ K Q 9	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
2♠	3♥	Pass	4♥
All Pass			

4♥ by North
Lead: ♠10

When partner opens 1NT, interference can easily gum up your smooth bidding sequences. Playing the lebensohl convention, your 3♥ bid shows a 5-card suit and is forcing to game.

It doesn't always work out so well, but here partner had an easy 4♥ bid.

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♠10.

Whatever you play, West takes the ♠ A K J and then plays a small ♣. East started with just one ♠.

Loser List: ♠ = 3 : ♥ = ? : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = ?

Don't let that Question Mark by the ♥ losers mislead you - if you are going to make this contract you cannot lose a ♥ trick at all! Is there any hope?

The odds aren't good, but you actually have **TWO** possibilities for success. If East holds the singleton ♥K, you can play a small ♥ to dummy's ♥A, dropping the ♥K, then finesse West out of his ♥J. Or, if West holds the singleton ♥J you can play your ♥Q, finessing East for the ♥K and at the same time smothering West's ♥J.

Which basket will you put your eggs into?

The answer is simple Bridge math! West started with 6 ♠s leaving him 7 cards outside the ♠ suit. East started with just 1 ♠, leaving him with 12 cards outside the ♠ suit. Obviously West is much more likely to have a singleton ♥ than East.

So you win the ♣A in your hand, play the ♥Q and let it ride if East does not cover.

Then you

Ahh, success.

But to tell the truth, the Bridge math wasn't really complete. Distribution-wise it was just fine, but there is also the question of strength.

The fact that West overcalled makes it more likely that he holds more high cards than East, and this skews the odds toward West holding the ♥K.

But think about it. If West does in fact hold the singleton ♥K, and if you cleverly drop it by playing dummy's ♥A it won't help you. You will then have to lose a trick to East's ♥J.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

♠ 9 7 3
♥ Q J 10 9
♦ 9 4 2
♣ Q 5 3

♠ A Q 6
♥ 8 7 4 3
♦ 8 3
♣ A 10 8 2



♠ K J 4 2
♥ K 5
♦ A K 6
♣ K 9 7 4

♠ 10 8 5
♥ A 6 2
♦ Q J 10 7 5
♣ J 6

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♣	Pass	2♠	Pass
2NT	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♦Q

In response to partner's Stayman bid you show your 4-card ♠ suit. Partner now bids 2NT.

In response to partner's Stayman bid you show your 4-card ♠ suit. Partner now bids 2NT.

Partner had ♥s, not ♠s. His 2NT bid is invitational, 9-10 points, so with 17 points you say 3NT.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♦Q.

Winner List: ♠ = 4 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 8

You need one more winner. Although the ♥K is a possibility, there is a real danger of losing 4 tricks in the suit if South holds the ♥A.

A much better idea is to try to establish a ♣ trick, a suit where you hold 8 cards.

You must give up one ♣ trick in order to establish a winner there. It is important that you give up that ♣ trick to South. North is the Danger hand because if he wins a ♣ he might lead through your precarious ♥K. So win the first trick, enter dummy with a ♠ honor, and play a small ♣, finessing the ♣9 when North plays low.

South wins the ♣J, but you win the game. South cannot profitably play ♥s, so he will probably continue with another ♦. But since the ♣Q will now drop under the ♣ A K you have your ninth trick.

This ♣ holding shows an important principle. As long as the suit splits 3-2 you can establish the fourth card as a winner by ducking one trick.

The key is your ability to choose which defender you want to duck the trick into.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ K 8 6 2 ♥ Q 8 ♦ A 8 3 ♣ K 5 4 3	
♠ 10 5 ♥ A J 9 6 2 ♦ 10 7 5 4 ♣ J 8	N W E S	♠ Q J 9 7 ♥ 10 5 4 ♦ J 9 6 ♣ Q 9 6
	♠ A 4 3 ♥ K 7 3 ♦ K Q 2 ♣ A 10 7 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♦
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♥6

With 12 points and a 4-card Major suit you automatically use Stayman; bid 2♣. Partner responds 2♦.

With 12 points and a 4-card Major suit you automatically use Stayman; bid 2♣. Partner responds 2♦.

You have plenty of points for game; with no 4-4 Major suit fit you bid 3NT.

The contract would be 3NT played by North.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♥6.

First big decision. Which ♥ do you play from dummy?

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 8

The Rule of Eleven tells you there are 5 ♥s in North, East and South which are higher than the ♥6. You and dummy hold 4 of them so you can place East with just 1. The missing high cards are ♥ A J 10 9. Elementary, Watson; East must hold the ♥10 because from ♥ A J 10 6, ♥ A 10 9 6 or ♥ J 10 9 6 West would **NOT** have led the ♥6. So your first smart move is to play dummy's ♥Q, which holds the trick. What next?

You need to find one more winner and your best chance is the ♣ suit. You will need a 3-2 split in the suit, but you must establish the ♣ winner without letting East get the lead. East is the Danger Hand because he can play a ♥ throughyour ♥ K 7. Therefore it would be unwise to play ♣A, ♣K, then another ♣ because East is very likely to be the one with 3 ♣s.

Did you get it? Play a small ♣ toward your hand and put on the ♣10 if East plays low. You don't expect the ♣10 to win the trick, it is more of a duck than a finesse. West takes this with his ♣J but he can do you no harm. If he continues with ♥s your ♥K will be a second stopper. If he plays any other suit you will scamper home with your 9 tricks, which of course now include those 3 ♣s.

A duck into the safe hand allowed you to establish the ♣ winner you needed.

But what if East had figured out what you were going to try and played his ♣Q when you led from dummy?

He would have been very, very sorry. You would have had no choice but to win the trick, and when West's ♣J fell on the next trick you would have all 4 ♣ tricks!

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

♠ A Q 10
♥ J 6 2
♦ Q J 10 8
♣ 9 6 4

♠ 9 8 3
♥ 7 3
♦ A K 4 2
♣ A K Q J



♠ J 7 5 2
♥ A K 9 8 5
♦ 7 3
♣ 8 3

♠ K 6 4
♥ Q 10 4
♦ 9 6 5
♣ 10 7 5 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	2♣	Pass
2♦	Pass	2♥	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by West
Lead: ♦Q

In response to partner's Stayman bid you bid 2♦ to indicate no 4-card Major. Partner now bids 2♥.

In response to partner's Stayman bid you bid 2♦ to indicate no 4-card Major. Partner now bids 2♥.

Partner's bid shows 5♥s, and by inference, 4 ♠s. You hand does not provide an 8-card fit in either Major, so with 17 points you say 3NT.

West plays 3NT. North leads the ♦Q.

Winner List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 4 :: Total = 8

You need one more winner and without question it must come from the ♥ suit.

Your problem is finding dummy entries, all dummy has is the ♥ A K.

You must find the ♥s split 3-3. You must also duck a ♥ to keep a valuable entry. Win the ♦ and play the ♥7, ducking in dummy.

South will win the ♥ and return a ♦ which you win in your hand. You now play your last ♥ to dummy, and if the suit was originally 3-3 you will win 4 ♥ tricks.

The "brute force" method for establishing dummy's ♥ suit would be to play ♥ A K, then another. If they split 3-3 your last two ♥s would be winners.

Of course you'd look pretty stupid to have those 2 ♥ winners in dummy and no way to reach them.

So you use the duck instead.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ K 10 ♥ A K 7 ♦ Q J 9 5 ♣ A K 8 2	
♠ 6 3 ♥ 9 8 4 ♦ A 8 6 4 3 ♣ Q J 3	N W E S	♠ A Q 4 ♥ Q J 10 3 ♦ 10 7 2 ♣ 10 6 5
	♠ J 9 8 7 5 2 ♥ 6 5 2 ♦ K ♣ 9 7 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2NT	Pass	3♥
Pass	3♠	Pass	4♠
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♥Q

5

With your 6-card Major suit you naturally use a transfer; bid 3♥. Partner responds 3♠.

With your 6-card Major suit you naturally use a transfer; bid 3♥. Partner responds 3♠.

Partner has at least 20 points so you bid 4♠.

The contract would be 4♠ played by South.

North plays 4♠. East leads the ♥Q and West plays ♥4.

You win the first trick with your ♥A. By doing this you leave East in the dark about who holds the ♥K. If you had instead won with the ♥K East would have known you held both honors since West would have played the ♥A if he held it.

Loser List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 1 :: Total =

You have 2 losers to get rid of and the good news is that you can establish 2 ♦ winners pretty easily. So do you start pulling trumps now?

No, stay away from trumps for now. You might have to lose the lead twice in trumps, and the first time they get the lead they will play another ♥ and expose the loser in that suit. Then, the next time they get the lead they will take their ♥ winner. You need to get rid of that ♥ loser **BEFORE** you start on trumps.

Play a small ♦ to the ♦K. West will take this and play another ♥ to your ♥K. Play your ♦Q and discard dummy's ♥ loser. Now you might just as well ruff that ♥ in dummy, (with the ♠7 to be safe), and play trumps from that side. It turns out that East has both high trumps but you don't care because dummy's ♣ loser can be dumped on your ♦J.

The ♦A was a "fast" loser which you couldn't avoid. But the ♥ loser was a "slow" loser. Slow losers can sometimes be discarded, but you may have to do so before you lose the lead too many times.

Did you notice that if the opening lead had been a ♣ instead of a ♥ you would have used the same technique?